

Text One

Brazzaville Beach

adapted from the novel *Brazzaville Beach* by William Boyd

In this passage, the narrator, a woman who is working on a conservation project in the Grosso Arvore National Park, describes a journey through the African countryside to a local town.



It was at Sangui that the tarred road began. I turned onto it, heard the empty trailer, towed behind the Land Rover, bump up over the curb and settled down for the long drive into town. Normally it took between four and five hours, but that was assuming there were no major accidents on the way and that the bridges were in reasonable repair.

I rather enjoyed this drive – I had done it three times before – and on each occasion relished the buoyant end-of-term sensations it provoked. Turning off the track in Sangui onto the crumbling, potholed tarmac of the main road south was like crossing a border, a frontier between two states of mind. The Grosso Arvore Project was behind me, I was on my own for a few days.

The road was straight, running through dry scrubland and patchy forest that spread south from the hills behind me to the ocean, two hundred miles away. It was early morning and the sun was just beginning to burn off the dawn haze. The routine was familiar. The first day was occupied getting to the town. I would spend the night at the Airport Hotel and the next day would be made up of a tiring round of visits to the bank and department store and the various merchants who provided the project with food, supplies and black market medicines. Occasionally, there were trips to be made to workshops and garages for machinery to be fixed, or spare parts searched for, and this could add an extra day or two to the trip. But on this occasion I was merely provisioning. A long day's shopping awaited me tomorrow. Then I would spend one further night at the hotel before heading back for home, a much slower undertaking, with the Land Rover and its trailer heavily loaded. Thirty miles an hour was the average speed.

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The road ran through an unchanging landscape. Every ten miles or so I would encounter a small village: a cluster of mud huts thatched with palm fronds; a few traders' stalls set out on the verge selling fruit and vegetables, sweetmeats and cola nuts. The journey was not dangerous but we were always warned not to attempt it after dark. I was never absolutely clear what we were meant to be frightened of. Brigands and bandits, I supposed: there was a risk of highway robbery after dark. I reached the Cabule River by late afternoon. The ramshackle buildings on the far bank marked the outskirts of the town. Our wheels rattled noisily on the metal planking of the ancient iron bridge. The river was four hundred yards wide here.

I drove slowly through the town. On either side of the road were deep ditches. A few brick buildings housed empty shops. In the mud-walled compounds beyond them smoke rose from charcoal fires as the evening meal was prepared. The first neon lights – ultramarine and peppermint – flickered in the snack bars and nightclubs. Music bellowed from loudspeakers perched on roofs or hung from rafters. In the crawling traffic, taxi drivers sat with their fists pressed on their horns. Children knocked on the side of the Land-Rover trying to sell me Russian watches, feather dusters, yo-yos, felt-tip pens, pineapples and tomatoes. There were many soldiers on the streets, carrying their weapons as unconcerned as newspapers. Old men sat on benches beneath the dusty shady trees and watched naked children spin hoops and chase each other in and out of the rubbish bins. At an uneven table two young men with shiny shirts played stylish Ping-Pong, stamping their feet in the dust and uttering hoarse cries of bravado as they ruthlessly smashed and counter-smashed.

The press of traffic nudged its way through the town centre, past the five-storey department store and the mosaic-walled national bank with its swooping modernist roof; past the white cathedral and the 1960s concrete Department of Mines; past the police station and the police barracks, with its flagpole and ornamental cannons, the neat stacked pyramids of cannonballs like the droppings of some giant rodent.

Then we turned and headed back north again on the new road to the airport, past the hospital and the exclusive, fenced-in suburbs. We drove past the convent school, past the shoe factory and the motor parks. The setting sun bathed everything with a gentle peachy light.

The airport was far too large for such an undistinguished provincial capital. A sprawling modern hotel was constructed nearby, but the airport and its white hotel were always heading for decline. Five arrivals and departures a day were all it boasted, domestic flights linking other provincial cities.

Text Two

How to road trip without a car: the cheapest and best ways to travel long distance

adapted from an article by Sasha Yanshin

In this passage, the writer gives advice on how to travel without your own car.



Trying to figure out how to do a road trip without a car? Whether you don't have your driving licence, are on a tight budget, or want to minimise your impact on the environment, there are many reasons why you might want to travel without your own vehicle.

While the image that springs to mind when you think of a road trip is probably a car cruising down a beautiful mountain road, or a cool convertible zipping around a coastal path, road trips are not reserved exclusively for those that can drive, or those that are willing to drive when on holiday.

Take the train and enjoy the views

Taking the train is probably the most common and popular alternative to driving and can be a great way to enjoy a multi-stop trip that doesn't require a car.

One of the biggest advantages of train travel is that it's often far more relaxing than driving – all you have to do is book a seat, turn up, and catch the right train; no route planning, no refuelling, no toll roads ... the dream! By eliminating the need to drive you're also increasing the quality time you can spend with your travel companions as well as freeing up a precious few hours to get deep into your new book and make the most of the stunning views outside (true for any public transport). The views are another huge plus point of opting to take the train – you'll often get to travel on super scenic routes that cars can't take, such as over a breathtaking bridge like the Glenfinnan Viaduct in Scotland (featured in the Harry Potter films), or through snowy peaks on the

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unforgettable Glacier Express in Switzerland.

Travelling by train is also much more sustainable than taking the car, allowing you to take in those breathtaking views while making minimal impact on the environment – a win-win.

Save money by riding on a bus

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Buses are often the cheapest way to travel in any country, with some unbelievably low fares available if you're organised and book in advance.

One reason some people choose not to take the bus is because they believe they're a little shabby and uncomfortable, but this simply isn't true! Many buses nowadays have added perks such as free WiFi, charging ports, air-conditioning, and sometimes screens for you to enjoy movies and music as you travel. Bus services also tend to be really generous with their luggage allowance, often letting each passenger bring a large suitcase plus a smaller bag regardless of weight.

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Admittedly, once you're all loaded onto the bus, the ride does tend to take longer than it would've done in the car. However we think this is a positive that travellers should embrace; you're likely to stop in small towns and see places you wouldn't have otherwise visited, and pass through really remote, beautiful places, meaning you'll get even more out of your road trip.

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Cycle the most scenic road trip routes

The most active and adventurous way to road trip without a car is by cycling – an amazing way to make the most of a place and really appreciate your surroundings.

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Choosing a bike over a vehicle will allow you to go well off the beaten track where cars can't venture, including country paths, mountain tracks, and thick forests, giving you a completely different perspective than the one you'd get from being on the other side of a car window. Of course, one of the major perks of a cycling trip is the health benefits for both you (you'll more than make up for all those indulgent holiday meals out), and the environment, seeing as bikes make next to no impact on your surroundings.

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Definitely give cycling a go. You'll have to travel much lighter and it's a little more tiring than driving, but it's so much more rewarding knowing you got yourself to your destination without relying on an engine, and will most certainly make for a super memorable trip.

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No matter where you're going or how long it takes to get there, it's not as hard as it sounds to do a road trip without a car. If you plan ahead, do your research and are prepared for a little physical exercise, you just might find that this type of road trip is even better than driving.

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